

Spanish A1 — Week 6 Vocabulary Reference

Crescere | Beginner Spanish | Week 6

Theme: Food, Preferences, and Restaurants

Gustar Structure

Gustar does not work like most Spanish verbs. The thing you like is the grammatical subject — not you. You are the indirect object.

Who likes	Pronoun	Verb (if subject is singular)	Verb (if subject is plural)
I	me	me gusta	me gustan
you (informal)	te	te gusta	te gustan
he / she / you (formal)	le	le gusta	le gustan
we	nos	nos gusta	nos gustan
you all (Spain)	os	os gusta	os gustan
they / you all (formal/LA)	les	les gusta	les gustan

Key rule:

- Gusta* → when the thing liked is singular or an infinitive: *Me gusta el café. Me gusta comer.*
- Gustan* → when the thing liked is plural: *Me gustan los tacos. Me gustan las empanadas.*

The most common error: English speakers say *Yo gusto el café* (wrong — this means "I am pleasing to coffee"). The correct form is always *Me gusta el café*.

Examples

Spanish	English
Me gusta el café.	I like coffee.
Me gustan los tacos.	I like tacos.
¿Te gusta la paella?	Do you like paella?
No le gusta el pescado.	He/She doesn't like fish.
Nos gustan las verduras.	We like vegetables.
Me gusta comer en restaurantes.	I like eating in restaurants.

Encantar (Same Structure as Gustar)

Spanish	English
Me encanta el chocolate.	I love chocolate.

Me encantan los postres.	I love desserts.
¿Te encanta cocinar?	Do you love cooking?

Encantar = to love / to really like (stronger than *gustar*). It works exactly like *gustar* — same structure, same rules.

Querer — Conjugation (e → ie Stem Change)

Querer (to want) has a stem change: e → ie in all forms except *nosotros* and *vosotros*.

Subject	Querer
yo	quiero
tú	quieres
él / ella / usted	quiere
nosotros/as	queremos
vosotros/as	queréis
ellos / ellas / ustedes	quieren

Polite formula: *Quisiera...* (I would like...) — used in restaurants and shops. Introduced this week as a fixed phrase; the full conditional tense comes in A2.

Ordering	Use
Quiero una tortilla, por favor.	Direct — acceptable, clear
Quisiera una tortilla, por favor.	Polite — preferred in formal restaurant settings
Para mí, una tortilla.	"For me, a tortilla" — very natural in group orders

Spanish Food — Spain

Spanish	English	Note
la tortilla española	Spanish omelette (potato and egg)	One of the most iconic Spanish dishes
la paella (valenciana)	paella	Rice dish with seafood, chicken, or vegetables
las gambas al ajillo	garlic prawns	Tapas classic
el jamón ibérico / serrano	Iberian / Serrano ham	Air-cured; sold by weight at market
el queso manchego	Manchego cheese	Sheep's milk cheese from La Mancha
la ensalada mixta	mixed salad	

el bocadillo	sandwich on a baguette roll	Spain; in Latin America = <i>el sándwich</i>
el gazpacho	cold tomato soup	From Andalusia
el cocido madrileño	Madrid chickpea stew	
las croquetas	croquettes	Common tapa
el pan con tomate	bread rubbed with tomato and oil	Catalan breakfast/snack staple

Food — Latin America

Spanish	English	Note
los tacos	tacos	Mexico; filled corn or flour tortillas
el ceviche	ceviche	Peru/coastal Latin America; raw fish cured in citrus
las arepas	arepas	Colombia/Venezuela; corn flour patties
las empanadas	empanadas	Argentina/Chile/Colombia; filled pastries
el arroz con frijoles	rice and beans	Staple across Central America and the Caribbean
el guacamole	guacamole	Mexico; avocado dip
los tamales	tamales	Mexico/Guatemala; corn dough filled and steamed
el asado	BBQ / grilled meat	Argentina/Uruguay
el mate	maté	Argentina/Uruguay; herbal drink, not tea
el caldo	broth / soup	Widely used across Latin America

Café and Restaurant Vocabulary

Spanish	English	Regional note
el menú	set menu (Spain)	Fixed price: <i>menú del día</i>
la carta	the full menu	<i>¿Me puede traer la carta?</i>
el plato del día	dish of the day	
el primer plato / el segundo plato	first / second course	Common in Spain
el plato principal	main course	
el postre	dessert	
el camarero / la camarera	waiter / waitress	Spain
el mesero / la mesera	waiter / waitress	Latin America

la propina	tip	Custom varies widely; 10–15% common in Latin America
la cuenta	the bill	<i>La cuenta, por favor.</i>
reservar (una mesa)	to reserve (a table)	
recomendar	to recommend	<i>¿Qué recomienda?</i>

Ordering Phrases

Spanish	English	Register
Quisiera...	I would like...	Polite — preferred in restaurants
Quiero... / Para mí...	I want... / For me...	Natural, casual
¿Qué van a tomar?	What will you all have?	Waiter to group
¿Qué me recomienda?	What do you recommend?	
¿Qué tiene de postre?	What do you have for dessert?	
¿Está incluido el servicio?	Is service included?	
La cuenta, por favor.	The bill, please.	Essential
¿Me puede traer...?	Can you bring me...?	Polite request
Soy alérgico/a a...	I'm allergic to...	
Sin [ingredient], por favor.	Without [ingredient], please.	
¿Aceptan tarjeta?	Do you accept cards?	

Café Drinks

Spanish	English	Note
un café solo	espresso (black)	Spain
un café con leche	coffee with hot milk	Common for breakfast
un cortado	espresso with a dash of milk	Spain
un café americano	Americano / long black	Widely understood
un té	tea	
un agua (mineral)	(mineral) water	<i>con gas</i> (sparkling) / <i>sin gas</i> (still)
un zumo de naranja	orange juice	Spain
un jugo de naranja	orange juice	Latin America

una cerveza	beer	
un vino tinto / blanco	red / white wine	
un refresco	fizzy drink / soda	

Useful Food Adjectives

Spanish	English
delicioso / deliciosa	delicious
rico / rica	tasty / delicious (also: wealthy)
bueno / buena	good
caliente	hot (temperature)
frío / fría	cold
dulce	sweet
salado / salada	salty / savoury
picante	spicy
fresco / fresca	fresh
ligero / ligera	light

Note: *Rico* with *estar* means "tasty": *Este plato está muy rico*. With *ser*: *Esa familia es muy rica* (wealthy). A meaning-changing adjective from Week 2 — use it here in food context.

Pronunciation Notes

- **Gustar:** /gus'tar/ — the *g* is soft (like in "go"); stress the final syllable.
- **Quisiera:** /ki'sjera/ — four syllables: ki-SIE-ra; the *s* is soft in most of Latin America.
- **Tortilla:** /tor'tiʎa/ in Spain (ll = /ʎ/); /tor'tija/ in most of Latin America.
- **Quiero/quieres:** /'kjero, 'kjeres/ — stress on the first syllable; the *qu* is always /k/.
- **Ceviche:** /se'βitʃe/ — three syllables: se-VI-che; *c* before *e* = /s/ in Latin America, /θ/ in Spain.
- **Paella:** /pa'eʎa/ in Spain; /pa'eja/ elsewhere. Two separate vowel sounds: pa-E-lla.